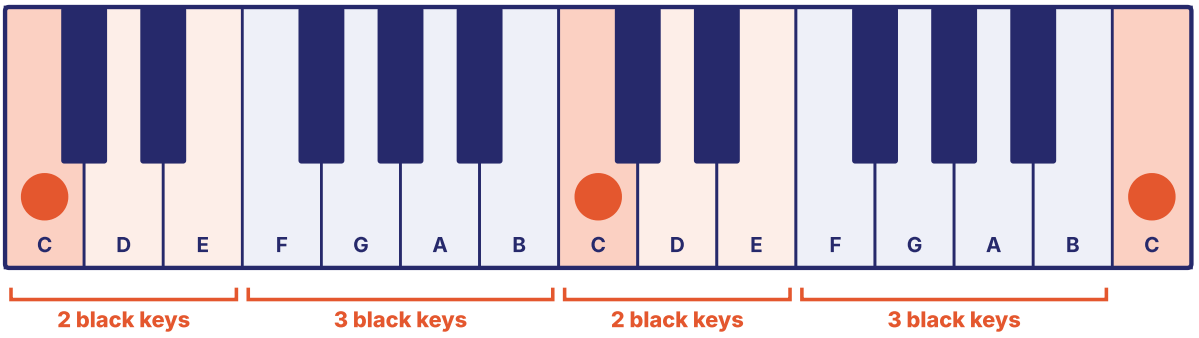
PART I · PITCH · 1

The keyboard

Left is **low**, right is **high**. The black keys come in groups of **two** and **three**, again and again: that pattern is your map to every key.

THE SECRET
Find the two black keys: C is always just to their left.



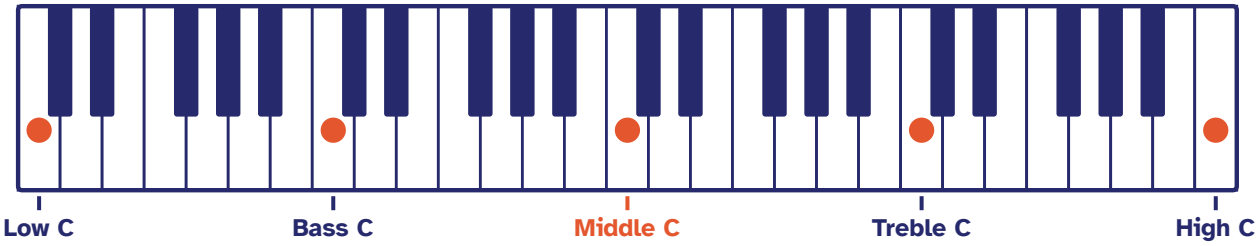
Every C sits just left of the two black keys

Seven letters, round and round

The white keys use seven letters, **A B C D E F G**, then start again, like the days of the week. **C D E** sit round the two black keys (pink), **F G A B** round the three (blue).

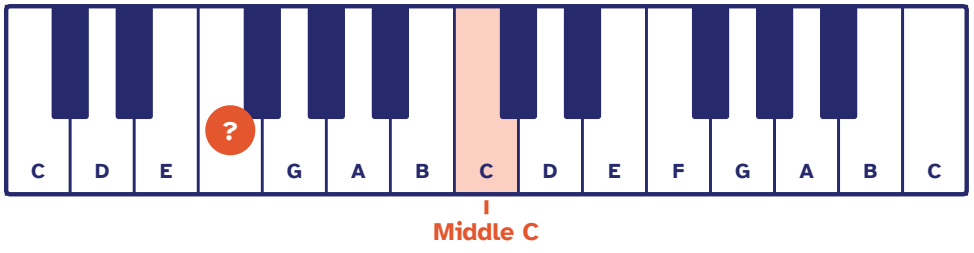
The five Cs have names

Find the C nearest the middle: that is **Middle C**. The Cs either side are **Bass C** and **Treble C**; further out, **Low C** and **High C**. From one C to the next is an **octave**: count the notes, C D E F G A B C, eight, both Cs included.



EXAMPLE 2

Find the F below Middle C



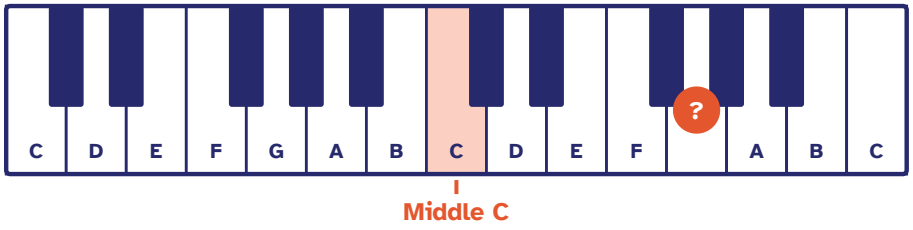
1. **Start on Middle C.**
2. **Look left** for the nearest group of **three** black keys.
3. **The white key just left of that group** is the **?**.

The **?** is **F**. Every F sits just left of three black keys, the way every C sits just left of two.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Find the G above Middle C

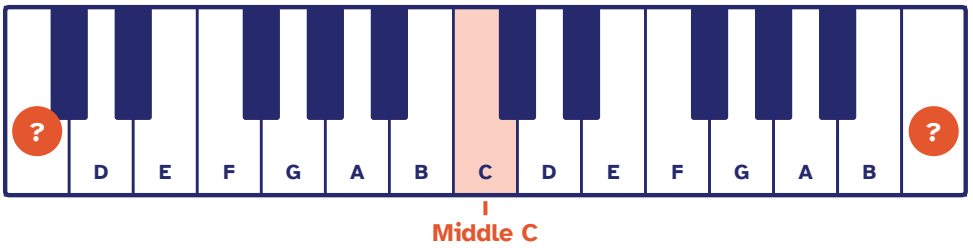


1. **Find Middle C:** the C just left of the two black keys nearest the middle.
2. **Walk up the letters**, one white key each, and count the notes: C is 1, then D 2, E 3, F 4 …
3. **Stop on 5:** that key is the **?**. Look where it sits.

The **?** is **G**, note 5: tucked inside the group of three black keys, between the first two.

EXAMPLE 3

Find Bass C and Treble C

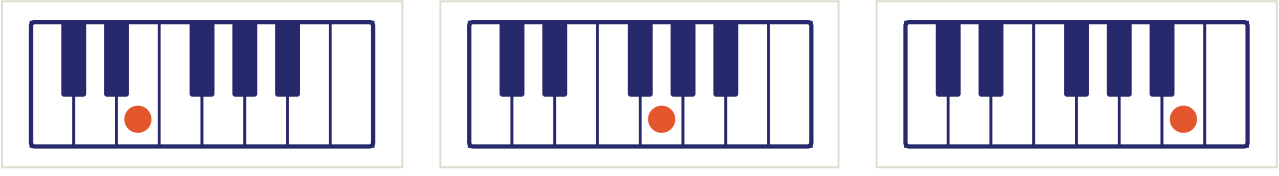


1. **Start on Middle C.**
2. **Walk left** to the next pair of black keys. The C just left of it is one **?**: count the notes, C B A G F E D C, eight.
3. **Walk right** the same way, to the next pair: the other **?**.

Left **?**: **Bass C**. Right **?**: **Treble C**. Each is one octave from Middle C.

GAME

Name the key



1 2 3

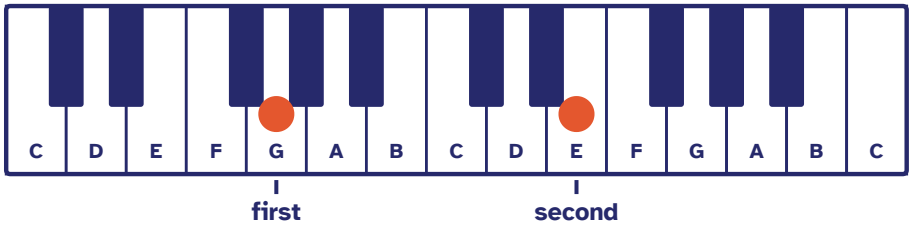
Each keyboard starts on C. Use the groups of black keys to name the red key.

Answer: 1 E (just right of the two) · 2 G (inside the three, after F) · 3 B (just right of the three).

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Higher or lower?



1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

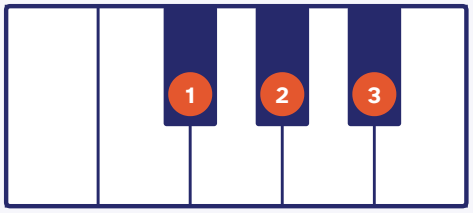


Play every C, bottom to top.

Say its name as you play it: Low C, Bass C, Middle C, Treble C, High C. Then play every F: left of the three.

YOU KNOW THIS

Hot Cross Buns, on three black keys



Play the group of three black keys from the top: **3 2 1**, 3 2 1, then 1 1 1 1, 2 2 2 2, 3 2 1. You just played a whole tune without one white key.

Try it. Find another group of three, higher up, and play it again there.

THINK OF IT The black keys are bumps you can feel in the dark. Close your eyes, slide your hand along, feel two black keys: the white key just to their left is C. Three black keys: the key to their left is F.

TRAP

× Mixing up C and F: C is left of the **two** black keys, F left of the **three**.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 25 · The staff and the keyboard p. 31

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 1 · Online: Library › Keyboard